Lifestyle Home Finder — Specification

Lifestyle Home Finder shows home buyers only the homes they can actually afford and that fit their lifestyle, ranked on a map as DREAM, GOOD or OKAY pinned matches.

Who it is for

- Home buyers in the US who know their monthly budget but not their price ceiling.
- Families who care about lifestyle, schools, safety and commute as much as the house.

Success looks like

- Every home shown passes all the buyer's hard requirements. Full criteria match will be ranked by % of match. Do not show any properties that are above their affordability.
- A search returns results in under 3 seconds. The time taken depends on search radius. Max 15 seconds to show results.
- A buyer can save a search and a shortlist (call as Dream List) and come back to them later.
- Each card links to the real listing, with the same property details as price, beds and baths the source shows.

Search inputs

Hard filters remove a home from results. Soft preferences only lower its match score. Nothing applies until the buyer presses **Find My Dream Home**, and the button must show a loading state while the search runs.

Location

- **State** — 2-letter dropdown. Default: TX. Required, US states only. Hard filter.
- **City** — text with autocomplete. Default: Austin. Required, must geocode. Hard filter.
- **Zip code** — 5 digits. Default: empty. Optional; overrides the city criteria. Hard filter.
- **Radius (miles)** — number. Default: 25. Allowed: 1–100. Hard filter.

Budget

- **Down payment ($)** — currency. Default: 50,000. Must be 0 or more. Budget input.
- **Monthly household Gross income ($)** — currency. Default: 8,000. Must be more than 0. Budget input.
- **Max monthly mortgage ($)** — currency. Default: 3,000. Must be more than 0; warn if above 36% of Gross income. Budget input.
- **Minimum credit score** — slider. Default: 720. Range: 300–850. Sets the interest rate.

Property

- **Bedrooms (min)** — number. Default: 3. Allowed: 0–10. Hard filter.
- **Bathrooms (min)** — number. Default: 2. Allowed: 0–10, in half steps. Hard filter.
- **Min sq ft** — number. Default: 1,500. Allowed: 0–10,000. Hard filter.
- **House type** — dropdown. Default: Single family. Options: single family, townhouse, condo, multi-family. Hard filter.
- **Max home age (years)** — number. Default: 20. Allowed: 0–150. Soft preference.

Lifestyle

- **Min school rating** — slider 1–10. Default: 6. Soft preference.
- **Max commute (minutes)** — number plus a work address. Default: 45. Allowed: 5–120; needs a work address. Soft preference.
- **Nearby recreation** — checkbox. Default: on. Means parks or trails within 2 miles. Soft preference.
- **Min safety score** — slider 0–100. Default: 60. Soft preference

Affordability

The app turns the buyer's budget into a **max home price** before searching, and any home above it is removed. With the defaults ($50,000 down, $3,000 a month) the ceiling is about **$378,000**, so the $1,135,000 home seen in testing (about $9,200 a month) must never appear.

Monthly budget B is the smaller of the buyer's max monthly mortgage and 28% of monthly income. The full monthly cost of a home at price P is: P

- $$\text{Monthly}(P) = (P - D) \cdot \frac{r}{1 - (1+r)^{-n}} + \frac{P\,t}{12} + \frac{P\,i}{12} + \text{HOA} + \text{PMI}$$

  D = down payment; r = yearly interest rate / 12; n = 360 months (30-year loan).

- t = property tax rate, taken from the listing's own tax figure when present, else the county rate (Texas is roughly 2%).
- i = home insurance rate, about 0.5% of price a year as a default.
- PMI applies when D is under 20% of P; default 0.5% of the loan a year.
- The interest rate comes from the credit score band, stored in a settings table the admin updates weekly. Rates must not be hard-coded.

Map and listing card

The map centres on the chosen city or zip code with the search radius drawn as a circle, and fits its zoom to the results after every search.

Markers

- One marker per home, coloured by tier, showing the match score (call it Dream Score) (for example "92%").
- Overlapping markers group into a cluster bubble with a count (Google's MarkerClusterer); clicking a cluster zooms in.
- The selected marker grows and gets an outline so the buyer can see which home the card belongs to.

Listing card (opens on marker click)

- The listing's own main photo; a grey "No photo" placeholder when none exists. Never stock or AI images. Do not show listing with no photos
- Price, estimated monthly cost, beds, baths, sq ft, lot size, year built, days on market.
- Dream score with a one-line reason per factor, for example "Schools 8/10 ✓" or "Commute 52 min ✗".
- Heart button to add to Dream List; close button.
- "View listing" button opens that exact home's source page in a new tab.
- Any field that is empty or 0 is hidden, never shown as "0 sqft lot" or "0 yrs old".
- The card must not cover its own marker; open it above or beside the marker.

Offline Search and Notify

- Add a check box at the bottom of the search screen which says “Offline Search and Notify”. Get email address from user to notify and save the dreamlist.
- If the check box is selected, the search parameters will be used to a search on the properties listed each day, and if it matches 90% and above, notify user email.

- Create an offline batch job that runs the search parameters with the listings on the day of run.